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Indian surfing has stopped waiting for the perfect wave and has started forming its own. Once a niche pastime known only in small coastal pockets, the sport now boasts Asian Games quotas, a historic international podium, and a team unafraid to paddle out against Asia's best.

The biggest breakthrough came early this month when Ramesh Budihal claimed a bronze at the Asian Surfing Championships (ASC) in Mahabalipuram — a result that signalled to the wider region that Indian surfers were here to compete.

This achievement built on the momentum gained at the 2024 edition in Maldives, when India secured its first-ever Asian Games berths in a sport making its Asiad debut, a few years after its inclusion in the Olympic programme.

The sport's debut at Tokyo 2020 lit a fire across Asia, with countries such as Japan and Indonesia ramping up their programmes, and India following suit.

"Since surfing was included in the Olympics, India started taking the sport seriously," said Budihal after his historic outing. In Japan, the effect was just as striking. "Having surfing in the Olympics in 2020 really brought that reach to the audience in so many countries," said top Japanese surfer Kei Kobayashi. "I didn't even know you could surf in India. It's so nice to see the surfing community develop here."

But ambition alone could not get Indian surfers into the line-up at major events — it needed resources, structure, and a willingness to take a gamble. Without government backing

and with scarce resources, Indian surfing was stuck paddling in the same place, waiting for a current to push it forward.

Taking the helm

The tides began to shift during the pandemic — a surge in interest not only boosted participation but also prompted a reset at the Surfing Federation of India (SFI).

The newly formed council, headed by president Arun Vasu, had clear intentions. "India needed the exposure and the competition. We wanted to send an Indian team to the World Games, continental championships, and international events," said Vasu, an avid surfer.

The teams relied on private support for years, hoping to put Indian surfing on the map and attract official backing. Training trips to world-class surf breaks in the Maldives, Indonesia, and Sri Lanka gave Indian surfers much-needed exposure to higher levels of competition and technique. Alongside these efforts, the Surf Turf programme run by the TT Group at Covelong Point, emerged as a crucial grassroots initiative, nurturing local talent and feeding them into the national team.

"Six athletes of the 12-member contingent are products of this project, which has been running for over four years," remarked Vasu, the Chairman and MD of TT Group.

Trend setter: Ramesh Budihal became the first Indian to win an individual medal at the Asian Surfing Championships. R. RAGU